

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SOMALIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Somalia must be pursued with great care and largely through the international, the diaspora, and the community, because this is a fragile, conflict-affected state where an armed insurgency contests the countryside, enforcement is weak, and environmental work carries real danger. Somalia is a Horn of Africa nation with one of the continent's longest coastlines and a semi-arid interior of acacia woodland and rangeland, and its environmental story is defined by three interlocking harms of a kind found almost nowhere else in this series. The first is the **charcoal trade**: the felling of the acacia woodlands for charcoal, the main driver of a deepening deforestation and desertification, and — notoriously — a taxed source of revenue for the armed insurgency, banned by the United Nations yet continuing still. The second is the **plundering of the sea**: the foreign fleets that have illegally fished one of Africa's longest coastlines, and the hazardous and toxic waste dumped off it in the vacuum left when the state collapsed — the very injuries that once drove coastal fishing communities to desperation and toward piracy. The third is the **drought**: the recurrent, deepening droughts and famines that degrade the land, ruin the pastoralist livelihoods, and drive desperate people into the very charcoal trade that worsens them. There is no landmark victory to point to. But the levers, largely international, are real, and can be used with care.

In a fragile, conflict-affected state, the tools are largely international and community, used with great care and protecting anyone inside absolutely — and they are real. The distinctive lever is the **charcoal trade's UN ban and the foreign markets that buy it**: the trade is banned by the world and reaches identifiable foreign markets that can be pressed to enforce the ban, cutting the demand that drives the felling — and the revenue that funds the insurgency. The **illegal foreign fishing and the toxic dumping** are foreign harms the **international maritime and anti-illegal-fishing frameworks**, and the fleets' own home and flag states, can reach. The **coast and its mangroves** can be defended, where it is safe, through conservation and community management. And the **international bodies, the diaspora, and the rebuilding state** offer real channels — the frameworks and donors, the Somali diaspora that documents and advocates from outside, and the federal government where it can act. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The charcoal trade is bound up with the conflict, so confronting it is dangerous and cannot be done by enforcement alone — and the people who cut and burn the wood do so in desperation, so they must never be blamed or punished, only offered alternatives. The plundering of the sea is foreign-driven and exploits a state that cannot yet defend its own waters. The drought is severe and climate-driven, beyond Somalia's power. The political space is fragile and parts of the country are contested and perilous, so the work must run through international, diaspora, and community channels and protect anyone inside absolutely. And no landmark victory is to be won. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the charcoal ban enforced at the foreign markets; the illegal fishing and dumping pressed through the maritime frameworks and the fleets' home states; the coast defended where safe; the international bodies and diaspora engaged — with great care, never punishing the poor, and protecting everyone inside. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely confront armed actors or defend the countryside from within, and you must never endanger anyone inside or blame the desperate. What can be done runs largely from outside: enforce the

world's charcoal ban at the identifiable foreign markets that buy it, cutting the demand and the insurgency's revenue; press the illegal fishing and toxic dumping through the international maritime frameworks and the fleets' home states; defend the coast and mangroves where it is safe; and engage the international bodies, the diaspora, and the rebuilding state — all with great care, offering the poor alternatives rather than blame, and protecting everyone inside.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Somalia is among the hardest and most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The charcoal trade is bound up with the conflict and cannot be met by enforcement alone; the sea-plundering is foreign-driven and exploits a state that cannot yet defend its waters; the drought is severe and climate-driven; and parts of the country are contested and perilous. This is not a fight for open, domestic confrontation. It is careful, largely international work whose realistic prize is the charcoal ban enforced abroad, the illegal fishing and dumping pressed, and the coast defended where safe — while the poor are offered alternatives, not blamed, and everyone inside is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Domestic authority is fragile and contested, so the decisions a careful effort can reach run largely through the international and the community: the **UN and the international frameworks** that ban the charcoal and govern the seas; the **foreign markets** that buy the charcoal and the **home and flag states** of the illegal fleets; the **diaspora and international donors**; and the **rebuilding federal and regional governments** where they can safely act. Keep clear of the armed insurgency and the contested areas, and map which international or community channel reaches a harm before spending a week on it.

How the Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The charcoal moves from felled acacia through the ports to foreign markets; the illegal fishing and dumping come from foreign fleets exploiting an undefended coast; the drought drives the desperate into the charcoal trade. You enter at the foreign markets and the UN ban for the charcoal; at the international maritime frameworks and the fleets' home states for the fishing and dumping; at the coast and mangroves, where safe, for conservation; and through the diaspora and international bodies throughout. Enter from outside, carefully, offering alternatives and protecting everyone inside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the charcoal: from the felled woodlands to the ports and the identifiable foreign markets that buy it, and the insurgency that taxes it. Follow the fish: the foreign fleets that plunder the coast, and their home and flag states. Follow the waste: the hazardous dumping and those responsible. Follow the drought: how it drives the desperate into the charcoal trade, and the alternatives that could relieve them. The leverage lies in the charcoal ban and foreign markets, the maritime frameworks, and the coast conservation.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak and dangerous, so the watchers a careful case engages are the UN and international frameworks, the foreign markets and flag states, the international donors and monitors, the diaspora, and the rebuilding governments where they can act. The charcoal ban and the maritime frameworks give the international watchers real handles, from outside.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Somali effort safely confronts the charcoal trade or defends the coast from within, and honesty requires saying so — the country is fragile and dangerous. What the careful, largely international tools can deliver is the charcoal ban enforced abroad, the illegal fishing and dumping pressed, and the coast defended where safe. The single most decisive move is **enforcing the world's charcoal ban at the identifiable foreign markets that buy it**, because it cuts both the demand that drives the felling and the revenue that funds the insurgency, and because it can be done from outside without endangering anyone inside. The charcoal ban and foreign markets are the distinctive lever; the maritime frameworks the reach for the fishing and dumping; the coast conservation the community defence; the diaspora and international bodies the channels. The realistic prize is real, pursued from outside and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the charcoal trade, the illegal fishing, the toxic dumping, the drought-driven degradation. **What framework reaches it?** — the UN charcoal ban and foreign markets, the international maritime frameworks. **Who is responsible abroad?** — the foreign buyers, the fleets' home and flag states. **What relieves the root?** — the alternatives for those the drought drives into charcoal, never blame. **How is everyone inside protected?** — the overriding question. Pick the harm the international frameworks and foreign markets can reach safely, from outside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case carefully, largely from outside. **Layer one: the harm** — the charcoal felling and trade, the illegal fishing, the toxic dumping, the drought's degradation, documented by satellite, international monitoring, and safe community sources. **Layer two: the framework and the responsible party** — the UN charcoal ban and the foreign markets, the maritime frameworks and the fleets' home states, the dumping's origin. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which international, diaspora, or safe community channel to engage, and the absolute discipline of never endangering anyone inside, never blaming the poor, and keeping clear of the conflict. A case built on the world's own charcoal ban and the international maritime frameworks, carried from outside, is one that can move the responsible parties and keep everyone safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **charcoal record**: the felling and trade, the ports and foreign markets, documented by satellite and international monitoring. Gather the **sea record**: the illegal fishing and dumping, the fleets, their home and flag states. Gather the **drought record**: the degradation and the alternatives the desperate need. Gather the **framework record**: the UN charcoal ban, the maritime frameworks. Gather the **channel record**: the international bodies, the diaspora, the safe community sources. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm nothing endangers anyone inside or blames the poor.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is international, diaspora, and — only where entirely safe — community, because open domestic work is dangerous. Build it from the **international bodies and monitors** who track the charcoal and the seas; the **Somali diaspora**, who document and advocate from outside; the **foreign governments and markets** that can enforce the ban and reach the fleets; and the **community and conservation actors**, only where it is safe. Frame everything around the international harms — the banned charcoal, the plundered sea — and the alternatives for the desperate; never blame the poor; keep clear of the conflict; and protect anyone inside absolutely.

STEP 4: THE CHARCOAL BAN, THE MARITIME FRAMEWORKS & THE COAST — WORKING LARGELY FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by conflict and danger, so the prize is the ban enforced, the sea-plunder pressed, and the coast defended where safe — from outside.

The Charcoal Ban and the Foreign Markets

The distinctive lever is the **charcoal trade's UN ban and the foreign markets that buy it**: the trade is banned by the world and reaches identifiable markets that can be pressed to enforce the ban, cutting the demand that drives the felling and the revenue that funds the insurgency. Press the ban at the foreign markets — and offer the desperate alternatives, never blame.

The Maritime Frameworks and the Fleets

The **illegal foreign fishing and the toxic dumping** are foreign harms the **international maritime and anti-illegal-fishing frameworks**, and the fleets' home and flag states, can reach. Press the frameworks and the responsible states for the plundered sea.

The Coast, the Diaspora & the International Bodies

The **coast and its mangroves** can be defended, where safe, through conservation and community management, and the **international bodies, the diaspora, and the rebuilding state** offer real channels. Pursued together — the charcoal ban and foreign markets, the maritime frameworks, and the coast and international channels — these levers press the harms from outside, while protecting everyone inside.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always from outside and carefully. **For the UN and international frameworks**: here is a banned charcoal trade and a plundered sea to enforce against. **For the foreign markets**: here is charcoal you should refuse, under the world's ban. **For the fleets' home and flag states**: here is illegal fishing and dumping to answer for. **For the donors and diaspora**: here are the alternatives the desperate need, and the harms to document. **For the world**: here is a fragile state plundered from within and without. **The golden rule**: enforce the charcoal ban at the foreign markets, press the sea-plunder through the maritime frameworks and home states, offer the poor alternatives, keep clear of the conflict, and protect everyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and largely through international and diaspora channels. Frame any attention around **the banned charcoal and the plundered sea**: a trade the world has outlawed

yet foreign markets still buy, and a coast foreign fleets plunder — never in a way that endangers anyone inside or blames the desperate. Carry it through the international press, the diaspora networks, and the UN and conservation monitors. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone inside; never blame the poor; keep clear of the conflict; and let the world's own charcoal ban and the maritime frameworks carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, international, protective of everyone inside, and never blaming the poor.

8A — To the UN or an international body: present the banned charcoal trade or the plundered sea for enforcement.

8B — To a foreign market or importer: press the refusal of Somali charcoal under the world's ban.

8C — To a fleet's home or flag state: set out the illegal fishing or dumping to answer for.

8D — On the toxic dumping: document the hazardous waste and those responsible.

8E — To a donor or aid body: propose the alternatives the drought-driven need, never blame.

8F — To the diaspora: coordinate the documentation and advocacy from outside.

8G — To a conservation actor (where safe): coordinate the coast and mangrove defence.

8H — To the international public: summarise the plundered state — from outside, exposing no one inside, blaming no one poor.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the charcoal trade or the illegal fishing by satellite and international monitoring; identify the foreign markets or fleets; write the one-page case grounded in the world's ban and the maritime frameworks. **The fastest-moving levers:** the charcoal ban at the foreign markets, and the maritime frameworks. **Emergency action:** where a shipment or fleet is identifiable, the foreign market, home state, or maritime framework is the sharpest, safest handle, all from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside, blame no one poor, and keep clear of the conflict.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but fragile, conflict-ridden, and plundered from within and without. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not open confrontation, but the charcoal ban enforced abroad, the sea-plunder pressed, the coast defended where safe. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase: the world's charcoal ban and the foreign markets, the international maritime frameworks, the diaspora and international bodies. And accept the honest limits — the charcoal is bound up with the conflict, the sea-plunder foreign-driven, the drought climate-driven — while still pressing the harms from outside, offering the poor alternatives, and protecting everyone inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CONFLICT — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but an armed insurgency that taxes the charcoal, foreign fleets that plunder the sea, and a fragile state that cannot yet defend either. Respond only through the **careful, international, and diaspora channels**: the charcoal ban and foreign markets, the maritime frameworks, the international bodies, the coast conservation where safe. Never through open confrontation, and never touching the conflict. **On safety and protection**: this note matters greatly here and governs everything. Somalia is a fragile, conflict-affected state where an armed insurgency contests the countryside and environmental work carries real risk. Work through the international, diaspora, and — only where entirely safe — community channels; never expose or endanger anyone inside; never blame the poor whom the drought drives into the charcoal trade; and keep clear of the conflict. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, carefully and largely from outside. The documented charcoal trade feeds the ban enforcement at the foreign markets; the illegal fishing and dumping feed the maritime frameworks and home states; the coast defence and the diaspora advocacy run alongside; the alternatives for the desperate run beneath it all. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the charcoal trade and the sea-plunder by satellite and monitoring; **months two onward**, press the foreign markets, the maritime frameworks, and the home states, and engage the diaspora and donors; **through the long effort**, sustain the enforcement and the alternatives. The core discipline: internationally pressed, community-safe, never blaming the poor, and protective of everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Somalia is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the charcoal trade can be safely confronted from within, or the coast defended openly, or a landmark victory won — none of that is true, and the country is fragile and perilous. What it claims is real: that the charcoal trade is banned by the world and reaches identifiable foreign markets that can be pressed to enforce the ban, cutting both the felling and the insurgency's revenue; that the illegal fishing and toxic dumping are foreign harms the international maritime frameworks and the fleets' home states can reach; that the coast and mangroves can be defended where safe; and that the international bodies, the diaspora, and the rebuilding state offer real channels. The levers work largely from outside, and the prize is the ban enforced, the sea-plunder pressed, and the coast defended where safe — not open confrontation. For a fragile state plundered from within and without, that careful work — pressed from outside, offering the poor alternatives rather than blame, and protecting everyone inside absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.